Well-being Conversations for Managers - Study guide

Practitioner course | Trainer: Grace Whitfield

About this guide

Start supportive conversations about well-being and know where your role ends.

These notes follow the video lecture for this course. Read them before or after watching, and use them to revise before the final quiz.

What you will be able to do

- Open a well-being conversation with confidence

- Listen without trying to fix

- Signpost to the right support

Why managers have well-being conversations

- You see changes early

- People often will not raise it first

- Your role is to listen and signpost

Welcome to Well-being Conversations for Managers. Managers are often the first to notice when someone is struggling. A change in mood, in quality of work, or in attendance can all be signals. Many people will not raise a problem themselves, because they worry how it will look. A short, kind conversation can make a real difference. This lecture covers how to open the conversation, how to listen without trying to fix, how to know your limits, and how to point people to the right support.

Your role and its limits

- You are not a therapist

- You are not expected to diagnose

- You can listen, support and signpost

It is important to be clear about your role. You are not a therapist or a doctor, and you are not expected to diagnose anything. What you can do is notice, ask, listen and point towards help. Knowing this takes pressure off. You do not need to have the answers. You need to be willing to have the conversation, to take it seriously, and to

follow up. That mix of care and clear limits protects both the person and you, and it keeps the conversation useful rather than awkward.

Opening the conversation

- Choose a private, unhurried moment

- Start with what you have noticed

- Ask an open question

Choose a private, unhurried moment, not the end of a busy meeting. Start with what you have noticed, in neutral terms, for example, I have noticed you have seemed quieter lately. Then ask an open question, such as, how are things, really. Avoid questions that push for an answer, like, what is wrong with you. Make it clear that there is no pressure to share. Some people will talk straight away, and others will not. Saying that the door is open, and following up later, is often what makes the next conversation easier.

Listening without fixing

- Let them finish

- Reflect back what you heard

- Resist offering solutions straight away

The instinct of many managers is to jump to solutions. In a well-being conversation, that can feel dismissive. Instead, let the person finish. Reflect back what you heard, for example, it sounds like the workload has been weighing on you. Ask whether they would like advice, or just to be heard. Silence is fine. When people feel listened to, they often work out their own next step. If a practical change is needed, such as adjusting a deadline, you can agree it together once they have said what they need.

Useful phrases and ones to avoid

- Helpful: that sounds hard, thank you for telling me

- Avoid: I know exactly how you feel

- Avoid: just try to stay positive

Language matters. Helpful phrases include, that sounds really hard, thank you for telling me, and, what would help right now. Phrases to avoid include, I know exactly how you feel, because you probably do not. Also avoid, just try to stay positive, and, other people have it worse. These shut the conversation down. Keep your tone steady and unhurried. You do not have to say the perfect thing. A genuine, simple response, such as, I am glad you told me, is usually enough to show you care.

Knowing your limits

- Do not promise confidentiality you cannot keep

- Know when to involve others

- Take immediate risk seriously

Be honest about what you can promise. You should not promise absolute confidentiality, because if there is a risk to someone's safety, you may need to involve others. Say what you can keep private and when you would need to share. Know your organisation's process and who to contact, such as HR or an employee assistance line. If someone is in immediate danger or mentions harming themselves, treat it as urgent and follow your emergency procedures. Knowing your limits is part of caring for the person well.

Signposting and following up

- Know the support available

- Offer, do not push

- Check in again within a week

Signposting means pointing someone to the right support. Learn what your organisation offers, such as counselling, an employee assistance programme, or occupational health, and also what external services exist. Offer the information and let the person choose. Then follow up. A short check in within a week, how are you doing, shows that the first conversation was not a one-off. Keep a brief private note of what you agreed. Following up is often the most valued part, because it shows that you meant what you said.

Your next steps

- Find your organisation’s support options

- Prepare an opening you are comfortable with

- Complete the workbook and the final quiz

To finish, find out what support your organisation offers, and write down the contact details so you have them ready. Prepare an opening sentence for a well-being conversation that feels natural in your own words. Complete the workbook for this course, which includes a conversation guide and a follow up planner. Then take the final quiz. When you reach the end of the last lesson you will receive your certificate and a personal review. These conversations get easier with practice, and your willingness to start them matters.

Glossary

Signposting: Pointing someone to appropriate support without taking on the role of counsellor.

Open question: A question that invites more than a yes or no answer, such as "how are things, really?"

Reflective listening: Repeating back what you heard in your own words to show you understood.

Employee assistance programme: A confidential support service some employers provide for staff.